Gruesome Playground Injuries

By Rajiv Joseph

A nurse's office in an elementary school. Kayleen (8) is waiting for the nurse. She's bored. Doug (8) enters. He has a large bloody bandage wrapped across his face. He seems dazed, but not hurt, not crying.

******** Age 8 *********

KAYLEEN: **(Pg 5-6)** What happened to your face? Does it hurt?

DOUG: A little.

KAYLEEN: I have a stomachache. My mom says it's because I have bad thoughts.

DOUG: Like about Dracula? I have bad thoughts about Dracula! *(explores the inside of his mouth with his tongue while touching his bloody bandage gingerly)* Blood tastes funny.

KAYLENE: It does not.

DOUG: Have you ever cut your face open? I rode my bike off the roof! I was playing Evel Knievel. He's a motorcycle guy. That's how I broke my face.

KAYLEEN: Your face isn't broken, **(Pg 9)** it's just cut. Can I see it? *(Doug slowly takes off his bandage to reveal a huge gash. Kayleen touches Doug's wound)* **(Pg 10)** Gross!

DOUG: Your hands are cold.

KAYLEEN: Because I wash them. You should wash your hands. They are grimy!

DOUG: *(showing his hands)* I fell! There's pieces of rock in them. *(Kayleen takes his hand and starts to pick pieces of gravel out of his palm. Doug is transfixed – he speaks quietly)* Ow.

KAYLEEN: Does it hurt?

DOUG: A little.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Humanity has been intrigued by love for millennia.*
ACTOR: *We've come up with so many ways to describe two people who are bound together*
ACTRESS: *soulmates,* ***ACTOR:*** *twin flames,* ***ACTRESS:*** *kindred spirits.*
ACTOR: *No matter what you call them, they are a couple that fate has decided* ***will*** *be together.*

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ACTRESS: *And although their paths may separate, sometimes for years, there is a force that draws them to one another.*
ACTOR: *tragedy . . .* ***ACTRESS:*** *heartbreak . . .* ***ACTOR:*** *self-destruction, or even*
TOGETHER: *Gruesome Playground Injuries by Rajvi Joseph*

******** Age 13 *********

The nurse's office. Kayleen is unwell and throws up in a trashcan she keeps with her.

DOUG: **(Pg 18-19)** *(enters hopping on one foot, in pain)* Ah! Ah! Ah!

KAYLEEN: What happened to you?

DOUG: I was rocking out.

KAYLEEN: *(impressed)* You were dancing?

DOUG: No . . . *(embarrassed)* It was the limbo. I jacked up my ankle.

KAYLEEN: *(with disdain)* Doing the limbo!

DOUG: *(in a mocking tone)* I heard that you thew up blood!

KAYLEEN: I didn't throw up blood. I just threw up.

DOUG: Want me to get you some ginger ale?

KAYLEEN: *(with a tone of superiority)* No thank you. *(beat)*

DOUG: *(boasting)* I can throw up whenever I want. I don't need to like stick my finger down my throat or anything.

KAYLEEN: You're disgusting. *(Beat)*

DOUG: **(Pg 23-26)** Have you ever kissed anyone? *(Kayleen rolls her eyes and refuses to answer)* I haven't ever kissed anyone. *(Doug starts kissing his forearm and the crook of his arm, as if to practice. Kayleen purposefully ignores him)* Do you want to practice kissing?

KAYLEEN: ***WHAT?***

DOUG: I'm just saying: I never kissed anyone. And I'm assuming you haven't either. And I'm nervous about doing it; so why don't we just practice so we'll know what we're doing.

KAYLEEN: No! I'm not going to kiss you! That's gross! I don't want my first kiss to be with you! *(not as adamant)* And I just threw up anyhow.

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DOUG: That's okay. *(Doug takes the trash can from Kayleen and sits it on the ground. He leans in. His face hovers just in front of hers. They kiss. They step apart, look at each other for a moment. Kayleen puts her hand over her mouth.)* What's wrong? *(Kayleen grabs the trash can and throws up in it)* Are you okay?

KAYLEEN: *(Mortified, she won't make eye contact)* Just go . . . please!

DOUG: *(thinks for a minute then makes some sounds deep in his throat. He grabs the trash can from Kayleen and throws up into it.) (Proudly)* Our throw up is all mixed together. Wanna see? So awesome!

******** Age 18 *********

Kayleen's bedroom. Doug enters angrily. He has one eye swollen shut.

KAYLEEN: **(Pg 31-35)** What are you doing? What happened?

DOUG: Stupid Girl Scout gave me pink eye! *(Takes cookies out of his bag and holds them out to Kayleen)* Here. I bought her stupid cookies.

KAYLEEN: These are Samoas – Where are the Thin mints?

DOUG: What's your problem?

KAYLEEN: *(dismissively)* Go home. I'm sick and you're annoying.

DOUG: Shut up or I'll give you pink eye! *(He starts rubbing his eyes and walks toward her like Frankenstein)* mmmh . . . PINK EYE!

KAYLEEN: Ew! Stop! Get away! *(Doug retreats)*

DOUG: How come you weren't at school. Are you sick again? You sure look weird. And you're all rude and everything.

KAYLEEN: *(Proudly)* Probably 'cause I had sex today

DOUG: What?

KAYLEEN: With Tim . . . my boyfriend . . . We have sex.

DOUG: How come you didn't tell me? I don't want you having sex with TIM! That guy is nasty.

KAYLEEN: *(defensive and a little sad)* It's not like we've been doing it non-stop. We only had sex twice. Once two weeks ago . . . and then today.

DOUG: Sounds like it was really fun.

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KAYLEEN: It wasn't, okay? It wasn't fun.

DOUG: You didn't WANT to?

KAYLEEN: I mean . . . not at that exact moment . . .

DOUG: *(angry)* I'm going to kill him!. I'm gonna kick him in is ugly skull!

KAYLEEN: Don't get all crazy. You're always so dramatic. Just forget about it. He's my boyfriend.

DOUG: No he's not! Not anymore! I hate him. I hate him so much. *(He puts his face in his hands, crying. Kayleen comforts him and he notices her arm. She's been cutting herself)* When did you start that again?

KAYLEEN: *(pulls back, pulls down her sleeve and crosses her arms) (quietly)* I thought having sex would, you know. I thought it might make me stop.

DOUG: *(Bringing her arm out and tenderly touching the cut marks)* Does it hurt?

KAYLEEN: A little. *(Doug kisses the wound)*

******** Age 23 *********

A hospital room. Doug is splattered with blood. He has a bandage across his face, covering his left eye. He looks dazed. Kayleen enters; she looks exhausted.

KAYLEEN: **(Pg 11 -13)** Dougie, what happened to your face? Does it hurt?

DOUG: The fireworks were awesome.

KAYLEEN: You shouldn't be left alone with explosives!

DOUG: I didn't want to be alone.

KAYLEEN: Oh, it's **my** fault? The night before I have to bury my father?

DOUG: What are you even doing here?

KAYLEEN: [They] said you came in and kept saying my name. So [they] called me. They thought you tried to kill yourself.

DOUG: Who tries to kill themselves with a firework?

KAYLEEN: I know. I told them you're just a dumbass. You'd never commit suicide because you wouldn't have any scars to show off afterwards.

DOUG: Why'd you come?

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KAYLEEN: I don't know. You know how I get. When you get hurt. You know.

DOUG: *(Matter of fact)* Doctor said I'm gonna be blind in one eye.

KAYLEEN: *(Quietly)* Dougie . . . *(She covers her eyes briefly with her hands)*

DOUG: *(Not sad, just observing)* It's gone. The whole thing. It just kept burning once it had punctured the eye. The burn really messed it all up.

KAYLEEN: You always had problems with that eye. When you were little? And senior year.

DOUG: Pink eye. **KAYLEEN:** Yeah.

DOUG: I didn't want you to come here. I mean, I'm glad you're here. But you have the funeral tomorrow. You should go home. Get some rest.

KAYLEEN: **(Pg 14)** *(rubbing her eyes, suddenly overwhelmed)* You don't understand the week I've had. I get a call at work to tell me my Dad's dead. Dealing with everyone. And this! Here's Dougie all of a sudden. **(Pg 47-48)** Where the **** have you been?

DOUG: I tried to find you.

KAYLEEN: I was here. You didn't look hard enough.

DOUG: Jeez, Leenie, you're here now! I found you! I missed you, Leenie.

KAYLEEN: Don't call me that. Nobody calls me that.

DOUG: I call you that. *(Beat, takes her hand, they both react to the contact)* **(Pg 15-16)** Will you touch it? My eye.

KAYLEEN: You don't have an eye.

DOUG: My eye socket.

KAYLEEN: That's disgusting. Stop being weird.

DOUG: You've always been able to mend my wounds.

KAYLEEN: *(Takes her hand back)* Well, I'm not touching your disgusting eye socket.

DOUG: *(begins to take off the bandage over his eye)* Do it. Heal me. The pills only last so long. Just touch it. You can make it better.

KAYLEEN: **(Pg 17)** *(with fury)* NO! I WILL NOT! I'm not here to TAKE CARE OF YOU, Doug. I am not a ***healer***. I don't care!

DOUG: ***Then leave! Get out of here! Go!*** *(For an instant they are both startled at the outburst)*

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******** Age 28 *********

Hospital. Doug is in a coma. Kayleen enters. She's never seen him like this.

KAYLEEN: (Pg 28-30) *(to herself)* Damn it. *(a long moment)* Come on, Doug. Wake up now. I'm here. *(to herself)* What am I doing here?! *(She takes some pills out of her bag and takes them, she tries a different tactic)* I am so sick of your shit! WHO GETS STRUCK BY LIGHTNING!? I hate to tell you this, genius, but getting up on the roof in the middle of an electrical storm isn't a brilliant move! *(She calms herself and takes his hand. Near tears – she touches his chest as if she has the power to raise the dead)* You have to wake up for me. I really need you right now. *(she looks at the pill bottle in her hand)* I'm trying to get healthy. Mostly. I'm not great. *(she touches his face)*

******** Age 33 *********

A sterile lounge in a mental health facility. Kayleen is staring into space. Doug enters. He walks with a cane and a pronounced limp. He wears an eyepatch.

DOUG: (Pg 40-46) Leenie. *(She doesn't notice. Louder)* Kayleen *(She turns to see him)*

KAYLEEN: I thought you were dead . . . You woke up? When?

DOUG: Five years ago.

KAYLEEN: You woke up five years ago? Where have you been?

DOUG: I don't know. *(Beat)* Did you visit me?

KAYLEEN: They've got me on about 25 medications or something. *(Beat)* I had a bad patch, Dougie. I hurt myself. My stomach. You know, it always hurt. And it got worse, and I just tried to take it out. I tried to cut my stomach out. *(Beat, Doug flinches)*

DOUG: Kayleen . . . You visited me, didn't you. In the hospital? I swear to God I heard your voice. You came and healed me. You raised me from the dead!

KAYLEEN: No, I DID NOT! I'm not your guardian angel, Doug, for God's sake look at me okay? I didn't come and see you.

DOUG: No. You can't lie to me. I see it all over your face, you were there. You were there.

KAYLEEN: *(with rage)* ***I wasn't there!*** What about when ***I*** needed somebody?! Where were ***you*** the last five years?

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DOUG: Kayleen, I'm sorry. . . . St. Margaret Mary's exploded.

KAYLEEN: So what . . . you went to pick through the rubble?

DOUG: No, I work in insurance now. I'm a claims adjuster.

KAYLEEN: You're such a loser.

DOUG: I know. So I'm walking on the roof and stepped through a weak board or something and I broke my leg in three places. It took them five hours to get me out. But listen: I'm stuck up there, waiting for them to come and all of a sudden I was like, ***Where the **** is Kayleen?*** All of a sudden, everything was clear . . . trapped up on that roof . . . That's my life, Leenie. That's my life without you.

KAYLEEN: Does it hurt?

DOUG: It hurts a little. *(Long beat)*

******** Flashback sequence *********

KAYLEEN: **(Pg 5)** I have bad thoughts.

DOUG: I have bad thoughts about Dracula! *(explores the inside of his mouth with his tongue while touching his bloody bandage gingerly)* Blood tastes funny.

DOUG: **(Pg 19)** *(boasting)* I can throw up whenever I want.

KAYLEEN: You're disgusting. *(Beat)*

DOUG: **(Pg 31)** Stupid Girl Scout gave me pink eye!

DOUG: **(Pg 35)** *(Kayleen shows her arms)* When did you start that again?

KAYLEEN: *(quietly)* I thought having sex would make me stop.

KAYLEEN: **(Pg 11)** [They] said you came in and kept saying my name. They thought you tried to kill yourself.

DOUG: Who tries to kill themselves with a firework?

******** Flashback ends *********

DOUG: **(Pg 46)** That's my life, Leenie. That's my life without you.

KAYLEEN: Does it hurt?

DOUG: **(Pg 49)** Come here *(Doug takes her face in his hands. Kayleen tries to resist, but relents)* Look at me. *(they stare at each other; Doug kisses her softly)* I love you …

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